

JUANA MARIA

The Lone Woman of San Nicholas Island

by
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1835 – 1853

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Few events in the history of early Santa Barbara caused a greater stir and sensation than the discovery in 1853 of an Indian woman on San Nicolas Island who had lived there alone for eighteen years. And few events in Santa Barbara's long colorful history have engaged people's imagination and interest as much as the almost incredible story of Juana Maria. Had this story been written as fiction it would have been rejected. But the story is true. The Franciscan padres of Mission Santa Barbara were involved in her discovery. Today they are involved in telling her story.

San Nicolas Island lies out in the Pacific about seventy miles from San Pedro. It is nine miles long and three and a half miles wide. It had been inhabited by Indians from the earliest times. In 1811 a ship belonging to Pope and Boardman of Boston, brought about thirty Kodiaks from Russian Alaska to San Nicolas Island to hunt otter and seal.

They were left there with provisions to be picked up again in a year and the ship sailed further south. Meanwhile a feud broke out between the native Indians and the Kodiaks. The majority of the native men were killed by the newcomers and the island